cinematographers for the film. Shot in natural light and at close proximity with the elephants, the film offers striking imagery of other animals in the forest and the changing landscape of the region. During the course of shooting, Ammu was so comfortable around the camera crew that she would put her head over the shoulders to look at the footage, noted Gonsalves. "She was adorably cute. She'd seek affection and come to the cameraperson," she says. "We had to take her away so that we could get some footage. We learnt about the playfulness, ingenuity and sensitivity of elephants."

As Gonsalves waits for the Oscar verdict on March 12, she is turning her lens towards other animals, environmental concerns and conservation efforts in her quest to raise awareness and build a sense of responsibility towards the planet. There's a project on cats in the Western Ghats and another on the orcas in the Pacific Northwest. But before she moves on, Gonsalves, along with Monga, is looking forward to organising a screening for the community—both humans and elephants—in Mudumalai as soon as they return to India. "They are extremely happy and slowly understanding what the Oscars are," Gonsalves says about the locals. "There are lots of visitors who come to see elephants and they get a chance to explain what they do." ■

Suhani Singh





A LONG JOURNEY (right) Sreemoyee Singh and Jafar Panahi; (below) a still from *And, Towards Happy Alleys*

CINEMA

A PORTRAIT OF EXILE

Sreemoyee Singh's documentary about the lives of Iranian artists is born out of years of labour and groundwork

Acclaimed filmmaker Jafar Panahi would often have one request for documentary filmmaker Sreemoyee Singh, whenever accompanying her for a shoot: he'd ask her to sing. Interviewing the Iranian auteur for her debut feature *And, Towards Happy Alleys*, which will have its world premiere at Berlinale 2023 in the Panorama section, Singh began the project with an intent to explore the lives of filmmakers living in exile in and outside Iran. Only much later did she understand that Panahi's requests had to do with his nation's strict 'modesty code'. "I realised Panahi got pleasure in hearing me sing, because he hadn't heard a woman sing in public in more than 40 years," recounts Singh.

The 33-year-old filmmaker remembers being subjected to a 'textual' syllabus till her undergraduate days, prompting her to pursue a master's degree in Film Studies at Jadavpur University. Not well-versed with world cinema at the time, it was a short module on Iranian cinema [where the class watched Jafar Panahi's *The White Balloon* (1995)] that changed her life. Coupled with the poetry of Farough Farrokhzad—who inspired auteurs like Abbas Kiarostami and Mohsen Makhmalbaf—it cemented Singh's belief in her PhD topic. "I started out wanting to explore the lives of filmmakers like Makhmalbaf, who was forced to flee his country, and someone like Panahi, who was heavily restricted in a post-revolution Iran," says Singh.

***AND, TOWARDS HAPPY ALLEYS* COINCIDES WITH ONE OF THE MOST HISTORIC PEOPLE'S MOVEMENTS SINCE THE 1979 REVOLUTION**

Around the time, Singh enrolled herself for a PhD, she also began making plans to study Persian in Tehran. "I knew I couldn't enter the country as a 'tourist'; that I would have to do my interviews in Farsi," remembers Singh. She figured her PhD stipend—around Rs 80,000—would last her about six weeks in Iran. After getting there, she knocked on the doors of local journalists and filmmakers, trying to get in touch with Panahi. A week before her return, with no response from him, Singh had almost given up. "That's when I got a Telegram message from Panahi: 'Hello, welcome to Iran!'". She wasn't so lucky with Kiarostami, who was in Cuba during her first visit, and became gravely ill and passed away shortly after. "There's a scene in the film where I'm walking down to his residence, it's a hilarious sequence," Singh notes.

Six years of labour seem to be bearing fruit given how Singh got her doctorate and news about her debut film's world premiere at Berlinale 2023, all in the span of a couple of weeks. Singh's documentary coincides with one of the most historic people's movements since the 1979 revolution. Did she think about including the current movement in her film? "I mulled over it for a month, and took a call not to include it. It's far too important to be included for the sake of it. I don't think it would've been truthful," says Singh. "However, my camera has filmed the many tiny sparks that have led to this massive outburst." ■

Tatsam Mukherjee